

SmartJourney: User Manual (Traveler)

SmartJourney plans a trip around Sri Lanka from a conversation. You describe the trip in your own words, and it builds a day-by-day itinerary from real, admin-verified places, with costs, photos and a route map. You can then refine the plan by chatting, save it, track your spending, and browse places on your own.

Web address: <https://aismartjourney.vercel.app>

Works in: any recent desktop browser (Chrome, Edge, Firefox, Safari). The layout also adapts to phones.

1. Getting started

1.1 Create an account

1. Open <https://aismartjourney.vercel.app> and click **Sign up** (top right), or **Start planning for free**.
2. Click **Sign Up**. You'll go to the secure SmartJourney sign-in page (Keycloak).
3. Fill in your name, email and password. **The password must be 8–12 characters, with an upper-case letter, a lower-case letter, a number and a symbol.** Passwords longer than 12 characters are rejected.
4. If asked, verify your email: open the email from SmartJourney and click the link. **The link expires after 5 minutes.** If it has expired, use *Click here to re-send* on the sign-in page.

1.2 Sign in and sign out

- **Sign in:** click **Sign in**, then **Sign In**, then enter your email and password. You land on the planner (**Home**).
- **Sign out:** click the sign-out icon at the bottom of the left sidebar, or use **Settings** → **Account** → **Sign out of SmartJourney**. This signs you out on this device, including single sign-on.

1.3 Forgotten password

Go to the sign-in page and choose **Forgot password**. The **Reset your password** page offers two options:

- **I forgot my password:** you're emailed a one-time link to choose a new password.
 - **I know it and want to change it:** sign in with your current password, then set a new one.
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2. The screen layout

Area	What it is
Left sidebar	New trip , your past chats (searchable with <i>Search your trips</i>), and links to Explore , Saved itineraries and Budget tracker . At the bottom: your name, Settings (gear icon) and Sign out . Admins also see Admin .
Centre	The chat with the trip planner.

Area	What it is
Right	The route map of the selected itinerary. Hide or show it with the Hide map / Show map button.

To delete a chat, hover over it in the sidebar and click the delete icon (**Delete chat**).

3. Planning a trip

3.1 Ask for a trip

Type into the message box ("*Message SmartJourney: ask about dates, budget, or a place...*") and press **Enter**. **Shift+Enter** adds a new line.

Include what matters to you: **where**, **how many days**, **who's going**, **budget**, **interests**, **pace**, and optionally **where you start from** and **dates**. For example:

- *Plan a 5-day trip to Kandy, Nuwara Eliya and Ella for two people. We love nature, tea plantations and train rides, mid-range budget, relaxed pace.*
- *3 days in Galle and Mirissa for a couple, budget around LKR 60,000, beaches and whale watching.*
- *Plan 3 days in Sigiriya, Dambulla and Polonnaruwa. We're into history and photography.*
- *4-day family trip around Colombo and Negombo with two kids aged 6 and 9, nothing too tiring.*

If you haven't planned anything yet, suggestion chips (e.g. *Plan a 3-day trip in Kandy*) appear under the chat. Click one to send it.

If your request is too vague (for example, "*somewhere peaceful for a weekend*"), SmartJourney **asks a follow-up question** instead of guessing. Just answer it.

3.2 While it plans

A status bubble cycles through *Finding places worth your time...* → *Sequencing the days...* → *Optimizing the route...* → *Estimating costs...*. Planning usually takes **5–20 seconds**, but can take longer when the AI services are busy. Click the **Stop** button (square icon) to cancel.

3.3 Reading the itinerary card

Part	Meaning
Header (e.g. <i>Kandy · 5 days</i>)	Click it to show this itinerary on the map. The badge shows how the plan was made: 11m (the AI planner) or fallback (a rule-based planner used when the AI is unavailable; still a valid, budget-checked plan).
DAY 1, DAY 2...	Each day opens and closes on a click. Day 1 starts open. The right side shows that day's cost.
Rows	Time, estimated cost, and the place name.
Photo strip	Up to six photos of stops. Click one to enlarge it, and use the arrows to browse. Restaurants have no photos (no free photo source exists).
Estimated cost	Total for the whole trip, in the trip's currency.

Part	Meaning
Save itinerary	Saves the trip (see section 5).

3.4 Your starting point (location)

If location access is on, trips start from where you are. If it's off or blocked, a bar under the chat says so. Click **Turn on**, allow it in the browser, or just write it in your request: "...starting from Colombo".

3.5 Asking questions

You can also ask travel questions ("*Is it safe to swim in Mirissa in July?*", "*What should I wear to the Temple of the Tooth?*"). Answers drawn from the knowledge base show a **Sources** list with links underneath.

4. Refining a plan (follow-ups)

Keep chatting in the same conversation to change the plan:

- *Make day 2 more relaxed and add a tea factory visit.*
- *Make it cheaper. / Show budget breakdown* (also available as chips)
- *I'm starting from Polonnaruwa instead.*
- *Swap day 3 for something cheaper.*

Only the part you mention is rebuilt. If you ask about day 2, days 1, 3 and so on stay exactly the same, so you don't lose the parts you liked. Each change produces a new itinerary card; click a card's header to put it on the map.

5. Saved itineraries

5.1 Save a trip

Click **Save itinerary** on an itinerary card. It changes to **Saved**. Click **Saved** again to remove it from your saved trips.

5.2 Manage saved trips

Open **Saved itineraries** in the sidebar. Trips are grouped into tabs:

- **Upcoming**: confirmed trips with a start date in the future.
- **Drafts / In Progress**: newly saved trips that don't have dates yet.
- **Past Trips**: trips whose dates have passed.

Click a trip to open it. On the trip page you can:

- **Set the start date** with the date picker. Every day is re-dated from it.
- **Confirm trip** (for drafts). This needs a start date, and moves the trip to *Upcoming*.
- **Change the status** with the dropdown.

- **Delete** the trip.
 - See every day's stops, and the route on the map.
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6. Budget tracker

Open **Budget tracker** in the sidebar. You need at least one saved trip. The trip's budget is the budget you gave when planning, or otherwise the itinerary's estimated cost.

1. **Pick the trip** in the dropdown at the top right.
 2. Read the four figures: **Total budget**, **Spent so far**, **Remaining** and **Daily average** (across the planned days).
 3. **Log an expense** under *Recent expenses*: click **Add expense**, then enter a **Description**, **Amount**, **Category** (*Stays, Transport, Food & drink, Activities, Other*) and **Date**, then click **Save expense**. The figures update straight away. To remove an expense, use its delete icon (**Delete expense**).
 4. **Spend by category** shows where your money is going on the current trip.
 5. **Budgets by trip** compares all your saved trips at a glance.
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7. Explore

Open **Explore** in the sidebar to browse places without planning a trip. Everything here is the same verified data the planner uses.

- Three sections: **Top Attractions & Hidden Gems**, **Hotels & Restaurants**, and **Local Events & Cultural Festivals**.
- Use **Search Here...** to find a place by name.
- Click the filter toggle to filter by **district** and **Minimum rating** (*Any rating* is the default).
- Click **See all** in a section to open its full list, with its own search and district filter.
- Each card shows the photo (where available), name, district, rating and price information.

If there are no upcoming events in the database, the events section says "*No upcoming events yet.*"

8. Settings

Click the **gear icon** at the bottom of the sidebar.

8.1 Account (fully working)

- **Profile**: change your profile picture (click the avatar), name and **phone number**. Your email is shown, read-only.
- **Travel preferences**: **travel style** (*Budget*: hostels, local food, public transport; *Balanced*: mid-range stays with a few splurges; *Luxury*: top hotels and private transfers), **interests** (tags), **default budget** and **currency** (LKR, USD, EUR, GBP, INR, AUD). The planner uses these when your request doesn't say otherwise.
- **Privacy**: **Enable location access** (see 3.4).

- **Security: Sign out of SmartJourney.**

8.2 Notifications and Subscription (preview only)

These tabs show planned features: trip reminders, weather and budget alerts, and paid plans. **They're interface previews.** Your choices there aren't saved, and no payments are taken.

9. Troubleshooting and FAQ

Problem	What to do
"Something went wrong reaching the trip planner"	The AI services may be busy (free-tier limits). Wait a minute and send the message again.
Planning takes a long time	This happens at busy times. The planner retries across several AI models, and if all of them are busy it falls back to the rule-based planner. You can click Stop and try again later.
The plan has few or no stops	The destination may have few verified places. Try a nearby district, or one of the suggestion chips.
The password is rejected	It must be 8–12 characters, with upper case, lower case, a number and a symbol.
The verification email link doesn't work	It expired (5 minutes). Request a new one from the sign-in page.
The trip doesn't start from my location	Turn on location access (section 3.4), or write " <i>starting from ...</i> " in your message.
Can I use SmartJourney on my phone?	Yes, in the phone's browser. A dedicated mobile app is planned but not built yet.
Is my data private?	Yes. Your chats, trips and expenses are visible only to you.